

A vintage typewriter with silver and teal keys is positioned diagonally across the frame. It sits on a sheet of musical notation with various notes and staves. The background is a close-up of the typewriter's mechanism and the musical score.

CREATIVE WRITING COLLABORATIVE
PRESENTS:

*Composing
A
Story*

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✦ SPOTLIGHT STORIES BEGIN HERE ✦

Birdies

Happier, by Marshmellow

By: Meghna Srivarshini

“Hi! My name is Liliana! I’m named after my mother, since I look just like her! Anyway, today I’m going to be telling you about the struggles and bird problems my mom went through as a girl. So, let’s get started...”

Once on a farm, lived a 12 year old girl named Lily Dorchester. Lily, as I said before, is my mother! I’m her only daughter and I wanted to make this story about Daffy, but I thought I should put a little bit of my mother’s story into it! After all, Daffy was my mother’s bird.

Anyway, Lily was a happy, jolly girl at her farm. She loved mooing around with the cows and she loved chasing the goats. But, she was only this happy, jolly girl at home. At school, she was a small scared little girl. The reason for this was because of a girl named Sally! Sally was a sassy and bossy girl who didn’t care about anyone or anything but herself! But most of all, Sally was a bully! She would bully anyone even if they did nothing to her! Even though she bullied everyone, she still managed to have lots and lots of friends, but of course, they were all just the same as Sally... MEAN!

There was only one thing that would cheer Lily up when she got home and it was her beautiful bird. Lily owned a bright blue jay bird named Daffy with soft, fluffy wings. Everyday, even when Lily wasn’t feeling sad, she went over to Daffy and opened her cage. She watched as Daffy hopped out of her cage and readied her wings for flight. The second Daffy was in flight, Lily felt like she was in a daze. She watched as Daffy’s strong wings softly pushed against the wind like she’s done it her whole life. Lily still stared as the flash of blue and black like a shooting star went up and down like a roller coaster. Lily still watched as Daffy soared out of the view like an angel frolicking in the air. Lily then turned her head toward the cage which awaits Daffy every night. This is Lily’s usual, daily routine cause’ Daffy chirps like crazy when she doesn’t get out. Even when it rains like crazy or snows, Daffy will still go out. In fact, Daffy likes it when it rains! I’m guessing Daffy thinks of it like a bath without drowning in the tub. Staying on topic, Lily loved staying at home, and it wasn’t just Daffy who made her feel better, it was the whole farm. All the animals in there just loved Lily. Sometimes, just running on the open field made her heart fill with joy! These were some of the best times Lily had in her life, that was before...

Lily’s days at school were like being hit with a sharp rock or like losing a race to an ant. Well Lily’s days at school were worse than any of that. Lily once told me that she wished for anything in the world that she hadn’t thought of the bad things and actually looked forward and not backward. In my opinion, when she told me that, I didn’t understand it at all! But, as I grew older, I realized that what she meant was that she wasn’t standing up to Lily! I wish right now I could go up to that stuck-up Sally and give her a nice punch in the face... Anyway, so my mom

had braces when she was in school, and kids would make fun of them all the time! Even the kids who also had braces made fun of my mom.

While things were getting rough at school, worse things were happening at home. A couple days after Lily got braces, Daffy got sick. The poor bird wasn't eating her food or drinking any water, but the weirdest thing was that Daffy still went out for her daily flying exercise. Lily started getting suspicious. Daffy stayed outside for nights, only coming back days later! Lily's parents had started to book an appointment for Daffy but the vet's hands were full and the appointment was only scheduled months later. Obviously, Lily was curious about what was going on, but she had much more stuff she needed to balance.

Her mother and father had put her in a girl scouts club so Lily can actually go out and talk to people and not be cooped up in the farm. Also to keep Lily's mind off of Daffy. Lily's parents thought this was a good idea and Lily would be happy, but Lily was the exact opposite of happy. Lily HATED the idea of having to make friends with random strangers in a girl scout club. And on top of that, she heard rumors in school that Sally is the group leader to at least half the clubs in town! So, there was a really low chance that the group leader wasn't Sally. Lily talked to her parents about this and the answer was comforting,

"Lily, what makes you think that Sally is the group leader? And don't you find it odd that someone your same age is a group leader and not an adult. I think that Sally may be a group leader for younger kids, like five year old or something like that." her father said. Lily thought over this and came to a conclusion that there was no possible way that Sally could be group leader.

What seemed like a year, a month went by and it was probably the worst month that Lily had gone through...

The day Daffy got home from being away for almost a week, it had been the middle of the night and Lily kept a close eye on her. Lily, curious, slipped out of her bed and looked a little closer at Daffy while she was sleeping, and noticed there was something under her. Lily carefully picked Daffy and glanced at what she thought was an... EGG? Lily was about to call her mom when she found that there wasn't just one egg, there were three! Excited, Lily placed Daffy back down on the eggs and sprinted down to her parents room.

"MOM! DAD! WAKE UP!" Lily yelled, jumping up and down.

"What?" Lily's mom groaned.

"You will never guess what I just found out!" Lily said, "Daffy's a mother!!"

"Daffy's a what!" Lily's dad said, with wide eyes.

"Show me! Prove it!" Lily's mom demanded! Lily, not objecting, yanked her parents' hands and dragged them over to her room, where Daffy's cage was. Lily carefully and gently lifted Daffy's wing which protectively hid the eggs.

"Oh no! This is bad!" Lily's mom gasped.

"Why is it bad? Isn't it good?" Lily asked, confused why her parents weren't happy.

“This means that all the while Daffy’s been out,” she paused, “she’s mated with another bird. So, technically now, she doesn’t belong to us. She belongs out there, in the wild.” Lily’s mom explained.

“What! No! Now that Daffy has eggs, they will eventually turn into baby birds! And then we’ll raise the baby bird right?” Lily said, half talking, half crying.

“How bout’ this, once the babies are born, we’ll take them and Daffy to the vet.” the dad proposed.

“Yes!” Lily exclaimed and hugged her dad tight. Lily could tell that her mom was giving her the “what was that for” look, and she could feel her dad shrug his shoulders, but she didn’t care. All she cared about was making sure that Daffy was still with her.

Daffy’s appointment to the vet was today and Lily couldn’t feel anything but stress. She felt like it was just yesterday she and her parents were going to the pet shop. Originally, they were supposed to get a hamster, but the second she saw Daffy, she knew that she didn’t want a hamster or any other pet, she didn’t want it, but she needed Daffy. Above all the stress for Daffy’s appointment, Lily’s first girl scout meeting was coming up soon, and the nerves were just getting to Lily. She had so many what if’s in her brain she felt like she might explode. Lily lay on her bed just thinking about sad days to come when her mom came in and announced,

“Your girl scout troop leader has plans for the scheduled meeting so they’re asking if they could reschedule it today. Is that okay with you?”

“Today!?” Lily said.

“I know it’s so last minute.” Lily’s mom agreed.

“No I mean, isn’t Daffy’s appointment today?” Lily asked.

“Yeah, unfortunately it’s the same timing and you can’t miss the first meeting or they’ll kick you out so...” Lily’s mom stopped, knowing that Lily got the point.

“There’s no WAY I am not coming to Daffy’s appointment! And I don’t even care about girl scouts! I just want to make sure Daffy’s and her babies are okay!” Lily sobbed, shoving her face into her pillow. Lily’s mom rubbed Lily’s shoulders.

“I know honey, but you gotta trust me here. I promise I’ll make sure Daffy is okay, and if something isn’t okay I truly promise that I’ll bring you home immediately to Daffy, ok?” Lily’s mom said. Lily lifted her face from the pillow and silently nodded. Lily’s mom left the room leaving Lily and her thoughts frozen like ice. What ifs crawled up Lily’s spine making its way into mind: “What if the doctor accidentally kills Daffy or the babies? What if one of the babies gets eaten by another animal in the office?” Lily thought. As more what ifs entered Lily’s mind, the alarm for Daffy’s appointment rang. Lily reluctantly slipped off the bed and out the door of her room.

Lily’s dad dropped her off at the girl scout leader’s house and left in a rush for Daffy’s appointment. The door opened startling Lily,

“Hi Lily! I’m Mrs. Robinson! It’s nice to meet you, come on in.” At the sound of Mrs. Robinson’s voice, she sounded nice and friendly. Lily walked into the house and Mrs. Robinson introduced her to all the girls. Lily smiled at all the girls, remembering that it was their first day

too. As Mrs. Robinson was saying the girls' names aloud, one name made Lily sick to her stomach. Lily looked around the room and found herself staring into the deadly scowl on Sally's face. Sally's pink fluffy vest with flowing sleeves just made her look more obnoxious. But the second Mrs. Robinson looked over to Sally, her destructive scowl quickly turned into a fake friendly smile. Mrs. Robinson led the girls over to a room with a big round table with chairs to fit everyone. Mrs. Robinson sat down at the big chair at the side of the table and, expectedly, Sally took the seat right next to Mrs. Robinson. Lily sat down next to a girl with brownish blackish hair like hers with red highlights in the front two sides of her hair. The girl smiled at Lily and she could see her red braces showing slightly next to her shiny white teeth. Although Lily felt like she'd seen the girl before, she couldn't place where.

"Now that we have all settled down, I want to announce what we're gonna be doing today-" before Mrs. Robinson could finish, Sally burst in saying what Mrs. Robinson was about to say.

"Oh I know what we're doing today! We're introducing ourselves!" Sally bursted out. Mrs. Robinson chuckled.

"Why, I love the enthusiasm of Sally but interrupting adults is very rude, but, I'll let it slip just this once." Mrs. Robinson said. Sally smiled with a little tilt of her head.

"Always wanting attention, but I mean, that's just Sally, right?" Lily turned her head and found the red braces girl whispering in her ear.

"You know Sally?" Lily asked in a whisper.

"Yeah, she goes to my school." the girl whispered back. Lily was about to answer before Mrs. Robinson interrupted their conversation.

"Well, I see you two are getting along nicely." Mrs. Robinson said. Lily and the girl's faces both turned red in embarrassment. Mrs. Robinson repeated what they missed out on.

"So we're all going to introduce ourselves in a circle..." Lily decided this was the best chance to answer the girls comment so she replied,

"You go to Prospect High Middle school?"

"Yeah, do you?"

"Yeah! So that's why I recognize you, you go to my school," the girl looked at Lily, then whispered back,

"I guess you do look kinda familiar," Lily would've kept talking but Mrs. Robinson interrupted them again,

"This is the second time girls, don't make me separate you two." The "introducing circle" started where you have to say our name and say a little bit about yourselves. Sally went first and obviously she made something up just to get attention,

"My name is Sally, and I like rescuing dogs from the animal shelter and making sure they get homes," Sally lied, as she picked up a napkin from the table and pretended to wipe her eyes.

"Aww. Sally is so heroic! You should get more credit for all you do!" Mrs. Robinson commented. All the other girls started saying other comments about how brave and courageous Sally was, all the girls except Lily and the girl with red braces. Once Mrs. Robinson calmed

everyone down, the circle continued. As the circle continued, it soon got to the girl with red braces,

“Hi! My name is Charlie, and I love playing my guitar!” everyone clapped and then it was Lily’s turn,

“My name is Lily, and I like to play with the animals on my farm, especially my pet bird Daffy!” There was a big round of applause for that, but it didn’t make Lily feel happy, it made her feel sad. The thought of Daffy at the vet just made her feel like wanting to go to the bathroom and hide. Once the circle finished up, everyone went home. Lily was surprised when Charlie said goodbye and also said,

“See ya at school tomorrow,” Lily laughed since there was no school tomorrow since it was a Saturday, but she still waved back as Charlie got into her car. Lily was feeling very anxious when she saw her car driving up the road over to the house. Once the car got over to the house, Lily got into the car and waved goodbye to Mrs. Robinson. The first question Lily asked when they got in the car was,

“Is Daffy okay?”

“Yes, Daffy’s okay! And guess what, the babies hatched the second we got there! The vet was delighted to see new born baby birds,” Lily’s mom said enthusiastically. Lily sighed in relief.

“Where are the baby birds?” Lily asked.

“Oh, the doctor said it would be best if they stayed at the office so they could check if they were healthy before we could take them home,” Lily’s dad explained. Lily felt disappointed but knew that they had to be healthy.

* * *

The weekend passed like a zipline and once again it was the dreaded first Monday of April which just happened to be the same day of Daffy’s baby bird vet appointment. Lily walked into Prospect High with baggy eyes and pants backwards. Then Lily saw Charlie getting off the bus, and so Lily started walking toward her, then stopped, thinking it would make herself look like she was desperate to have friends. (Which she was) Lily started walking towards her homeroom class pretending not to see Charlie, but soon enough, Charlie spotted Lily.

“Hey Lily! Wait up!” Charlie called.

“Oh hi!” Lily said.

“So, did you see Sally?” Charlie asked.

“No, why?”

“She was wearing a shirt, with a picture of herself on it!”

“I mean, is that really unexpected of her? Isn’t it kind of obvious that she just loves being obnoxious,” Lily replied. They talked all the way till Lily’s homeroom where they separated and went to their own classrooms. And for the first time in Prospect High, Lily felt happy!

When Lily got home from school, she came with a smile on her face. “Well someone had a good day at school today!” Lily’s dad greeted.

“I got an A+ on my math test today!” Lily announced. She wasn’t lying, she really did get an A+ on her test.

“Oh that’s great honey!” Lily’s mom came bursting out of the kitchen with a spatula in her hand and her apron more stained than ever. “Hey, just so you know, you should probably go get ready for Daffy’s appointment!”

“Oh right!” Lily said nervously. Lily walked upstairs to her room where Daffy’s cage was. She was disappointed to see it empty but picked up all her toys (just one squeaky toy) and walked back downstairs. Lily was surprised to see her mom all dressed up ready to go and out of her stained apron so fast. Lily was about to call her dad to go, but he was already in the car.

“Hello Dorchester Family! Nice to see you again!” the woman at the front desk greeted them, “How’s Daffy doing?”

“Oh we actually don’t know, she was left here to make sure her babies are okay,” Lily’s mom explained.

“Oh right I forgot! Daffy gave birth!” the woman said, “I’ll lead you guys right over to Mr. Doctero!”

“Mrs and Mr Dorchester, how are you doing today!” Mr. Doctero greeted. “Oh, and how are you doing Lily?”

“Uh, fine I guess. How’s Daffy doing?” Lily inquired. Once Daffy’s name was mentioned, Mr. Doctero turned pale and nervous.

“Well...” Mr. Doctero paused. The woman at the front desk suddenly walked in bringing in Daffy and her babies.

“Aww! The babies are so cute!” Lily cooed. The three babies, frightened, hid under the protection of Daffy but Daffy showed no sign of hostilities. Instead, her head perked up and she chirped a nice melody.

“Actually, we checked them to see if they were healthy... and only one was.” Mr. Doctero said quietly.

“Wait! That means that two have to be... be.” Before Lily could finish, she shoved her face into her dad’s shirt.

“Yes, it means that they will have to be put to sleep.” Mr. Doctero said with his face ducked in shame. “We really tried to see if we could nurse them back to health, but they were already born weak and fragile,” Hearing this news made Lily just want to go into a closet and hide. Seeing this, made Lily’s mom feel sad for her daughter.

“Isn’t there anything you could do for the babies?” Lily’s mom asked. Mr. Doctero shook his head.

“Sadly, no. We should... um... do the thing before the other baby catches the disease.”

“Put them to sleep?” Lily asked, finally getting her face out of her dad’s shirt. Anyone could be sure that Lily really loved the babies by just seeing her face. Her eyes were red and puffy from crying and really her whole face looked saggy.

“Yes. We have to put them to sleep.” Mr. Doctero answered, still with his head ducked in shame for not being able to cure the babies.

“May we have a moment alone with them? The babies I mean.” Lily asked.

“Of course.” Mr. Doctero replied. He walked out of the room, taking small little steps. As much as he loved being a vet, he hated the part where he had to put animals to sleep. Lily walked over to the birds and muttered,

“I want you to be happier,” she muttered. Lily stepped back and watched a nurse take the two sick baby birds and leave Daffy and the last baby in the cage. Lily could hear the weak chirps of the poor babies who couldn’t survive. Lily couldn’t hold in the rest of her tears any longer. She turned around once again and buried her face into her dad’s shirt, which was now soaked, and she let the tears pour out.

* * *

“So yeah! That’s really what my mom had to go through, just as a 12 year old-”

“Lily! Are you retelling what I went through as a 12 year old in the mirror?” my mom walks into my room.

“No!? I’m recording it this time!”

“Well, did you show Puddles to them yet?”

“Oh yeah! I forgot to tell them about Puddles! So Puddles is basically the only baby bird that survived when the rest of his siblings, well, passed away. He’s exactly like Daffy!”

“Lily! You know I don’t like talking about Daffy!”

“Right! Sorry. I’ll turn the camera off now. BYE PEOPLE!” BEEP BEEP BEEP!

The Magic Gem of Nature
Under the Surface, from Encanto
By: Mohnish Premnath

Once upon a time, there was a family living in a plain field where it rained once a month. They were no ordinary family. Their ancestors were the guardians of the Gem of Nature. Each family member was granted a special power to help and protect Nature or where they lived. The Mother had the power to Rewind, and the Father had the power to Fast forward. The Grandpa could heal any living thing. The Grandma had the power of freezing objects. The Uncle could control the weather and the Aunt could fly. Joe could see far away things, and Mint had super speed. Lisa had super strength, and Margo could talk to animals. The Gem of Nature was placed on a special statue in the shape of a Dragon. The Gem grew all sorts of vegetables, and gave rain whenever they needed it.

One day, the birds and crows were eating the corn inside the farm. One of the crows saw a shiny thing that was inside the statue. It went closer and tried to grab it, but the Gem was stuck. The crow tried again and again until it came out. The crow tries to carry it to its nest, but drops it into a big rock. Then a herd of deer hit the gem into a tree. A bird took it to its nest, but fell into a bunny hole. The bunny throws the gem outside in the mud, where the beavers take it thinking it

is a stick. They block their dam, but they need more sticks, and the river broke through the dam. The water washed the mud off the gem, and it drifted into a waterfall. The gem fell down, and an eagle caught it and brought it to the mountain.

The family came out of their house and all of them shouted “NOOOO!”

“Where did the Magic gem go,” shouted Mint

Grandpa said, “We need to find the Gem of Nature before something bad happens.” They all agreed and started looking for the Gem everywhere, but nothing was found. Grandma told everyone that the garden was gone, and all the vegetables were rotten. Margo told Joe to use his power of looking at far away things. Joe found the Gem, but it was on top of a high mountain. They began their travels. Lisa, Margo, Mint, and Joe went to find the gem, because Margo can talk to animals and can get help. Lisa can help with the heavy things, Mint can cover more areas with his super speed, and Joe can spot the gem and tell the way. Margo called some deer, and they began to ride through the pathways to the Gem.

They rode the deers until they arrived at a river. They stopped and camped for the night there. They drank the water from the river. The next morning, they woke up, and they saw a beaver bring giant trunks, and started building a dam. Suddenly, while the beavers were building, the water gushed out and one of the beavers fell into the river and was drifting rapidly towards a waterfall. Lisa immediately ran on the pathway next to the river. She took a tree and threw it to make a bridge. Lisa climbed up and grabbed the beaver. The beavers helped them.

Margo told the others, “The beavers want to give us some wood.” They continued their path down the waterfall, and arrived at a small village. The people there welcomed them and showed them around. They rested there for the night, and continued the next morning. They came to a meadow. While they had their lunch, Joe spotted a hole in front of a bush. Mint went over to check it, but he fell down the hole. The others followed him, and they found themselves in ancient Rome, and they were captured. They all watched how the other people captured were transformed into gladiators and fought lions and other gladiators. Finally, they saw Hercules go and fight the legendary Cerberous. Hercules was getting thrown everywhere. Cerberus knocked down Hercules, and was going to stomp him. Just when Lisa broke the cell door and punched Cerberus's middle face. The Evil king of Rome told his guards to capture the prisoner, and that is what happened. The guards tamed Cerberus, and captured Hercules. They let Lisa fight the monster alone.

Hercules asked her, “Who are you?”

She told him, “I am Lisa and my sister and cousins are prisoners. We fell through a hole and landed here.”

Hercules replied, “Cerberus has three heads and they represent the past, present, and the future. The first head must have accidentally made a hole towards here. Are you going to be okay fighting it?”

Lisa whispered to him, “I will be okay. Will you be able to reach that rope and throw it to me?”

“I can see what I can do,” He replied back. It was Lisa’s turn to fight the beast. She was given a sword and a shield, but she refused. The beast charged at her, and she charged at him. Lisa jumped and punched the first head. The other two heads knocked Lisa to the ground. Lisa got up and ran under Cerberus and grabbed his tail and threw him to the side of the stadium. She thought that she won, but Cerberus kicked her to the middle of the stadium. Just about when Cerberus was about to crush Lisa, Hercules escaped and threw the rope to her. She ran all around Cerberus tying the rope. Cerberus couldn't move and he was defeated. Everyone was shocked and in awe. Lisa and Hercules rescued the others, and they escaped. The Evil king ordered the guards to go and get them back. Hercules and his new friends ran through the village. They hid themselves in an empty house.

Hercules asked them, “What are we going to do now? We are fugitives and the guards are inspecting the entire village, just for us.”

“We have to find a way to defeat the Evil king, and save Ancient Rome,” Replied Margo. They started looking for things they could use. Lisa took a broom, while the others took vases and pots and other delicate containers. The others took the vases and threw it somewhere else to distract the guards. Lisa secretly defeated the guards one by one. They disguised themselves and made their way to the emperor's palace, and went to the weapon storage room. They got all they could, and headed straight towards the Evil king. There was an epic battle between the guards and the children. Finally, Hercules was fighting the king on the edge of the palace. Hercules hit the king's sword and the king pushed hercules to the floor. The king grabbed Hercules’s sword, and was about to kill hercules, just when Lisa came and pushed the king off the edge and that was the last time they saw him. Hercules got reunited with his family and he lived happily ever after, but that was not the end of the story for the Children. They found another way home and they went through, but it was not home. Instead, they ended up in a circus, on the other side of the world.

“What are we going to do now?” Asked Mint

Margo said, “Joe use your super vision and see where we are.”

Joe followed Margo’s instructions and replied, “We are in a circus, far away from home.”

“NOOOOOOOO,” shouted Mint

Lisa said, “Calm down, Let’s look around and find something. They went into the circus to explore all the things. It looks like there was a show going on. There were only some old people sitting there, and they weren’t even paying any attention to the Circus. There was an elephant bouncing on a ball. Three dogs going over one easy hoop, horses dancing, monkeys on the trapeze and everyone messed up. The three dogs got stuck, and the elephant fell down, the monkeys were tired and failing, and the horses tripped. That made the clowns and jugglers embarrassed. The old people went back to the home for old retired people. The owner came out and was ashamed of what they did.

Lisa asked, “Mr. Owner, what is going on ?”

He replied, “My name is Mr. Lee. We are a traveling circus and we go all over the world

trying to make people happy. We had a famous tightrope walker who would wow the audience and she would lead everyone. But she left because she had more important work than just working at a Circus.”

The Children made a little deal with Mr. Lee. They said that if they help him, then they have to be delivered back to their home. Mr. Lee agreed and they began to work. Margo taught the animals what to do and she became a horse dancer. Mint became a trapeze actor, and Joe trained with the elephant on the ball. Lisa volunteered to tightrope walk. She was given a pole with equally five donkeys on each end. She tried many times, but she couldn't find her balance. The others were ready and took a break. Lisa kept trying, she did it all day, and she did it all night. Finally, She found her balance and she could even do tricks on the rope.

Margo asked Lisa, “Are you going to be okay?”

Lisa replied, “I was berserk as a tightrope walker in a thirty-ring Circus. Now I am ready.”

It was time for the show. Everyone was ready and began the show. Everyone did their parts and the old people were amazed. They traveled around the whole world doing many shows and wowing audiences. The more shows they made, the more people came. Soon, even kids came to watch the show. Everyone wanted to see the new Circus. As Mr. Lee promised, He drove his train all the way towards their home. Once they arrived, they continued their journey. They were almost near the mountain. Everyone gathered their stuff and they rode in a herd of deer.

Margo said, “The deer say that they are going behind the mountain. We should ride them, and get to the mountain.”

They continued their journey. They wanted to know which way they were heading and the place. Luckily, Margo brought a map, and she used it.

She said, “We are heading in the right direction. We just need to go around this spot, and we will arrive.”

Mint replied, “Why can't we just go through the spot you are talking about.”

Lisa joined and announced, “Yes, we will go through the spot and reach the mountain faster.”

That is what they did, they waited until they arrived at the spot. It only took a second to realize that it was Falling Rock Canyon. They all checked how deep it was. The canyon was as deep as the Grand canyon. There were Giant long rocks with Giant rocks on the top. No wonder that it was called Falling Rock canyon. They all carefully climbed down. Mint had super speed, so he just ran down the canyon. The others were carried by Lisa. Once they arrived at the bottom, they thought of how to get through a canyon that you can get squished in. They were thinking, while Mint was having some fun. He accidentally ran into the canyon and rocks started falling. He was running and running, and no boulder was hitting him. He made it past the canyon. Now it was the other's turn.

Margo asked, “What are we going to do ? We don't have super speed.”

Lisa said, “I have an idea. You guys will walk slowly with me. I will carry the boulders and throw them away. When I say run, we run to the Finish.”

They agreed with the idea that Lisa had. Lisa first told them to walk slowly, and that's what they did. Then they started jogging a little, and Lisa had to hold more boulders. Finally, it was time to run. They got their feet ready, and they ran as fast as they could. Suddenly, boulders were falling everywhere. Lisa caught all of them, and accidentally threw them in the direction of Margo and Mint. The boulders were going to crush them, just when Mint ran quickly and grabbed both of them, and ran away from the boulders.

Lisa asked "Are you guys Okay? I am so sorry."

Margo said, "Yes, we are okay. Mint has saved us."

Lisa complimented, "Thank you Mint."

Mint replied, "It was no problem."

They all started walking slowly, and the boulders seemed to be calm. They all started jogging a little, and boulders were about to get tipped over. Then, they started running and the boulders were immediately falling everywhere. Lisa decided to punch and smash the boulders, instead of carrying it, and throwing it away. They all made it and were joyful. Next, they needed to find out how to get out of the canyon. Mint tried running up there, but he did not make it up the canyon. He was so close. Then, Lisa tried climbing there, but that didn't work out either. She finally tried to stomp so hard that she would fly up there. That did not work. They thought of a plan and that is what they did. Lisa stomped so hard that she got half way, and she threw Mint all the way to the top. They didn't see Mint. It seemed like Mint had left them. Suddenly, a vine came down and there was Mint. Everyone climbed the vine, and made it to the top. Margo took the vine, just in case. They all started running towards the mountain. They felt like they almost made it, but there was something in the way.

Lisa asked, "Where are we ? Is this the right place ?"

Margo replied, "We are supposed to arrive at the mountain. There is nothing like this on the map."

Suddenly, They saw a worker and Lisa asked, "Excuse me, What is this place?"

The worker replied, "Why, this is the ball factory. We started this factory 3 years ago."

Margo showed the worker her map, and the worker said, "This map was made 4 years ago."

Mint asked, "We need a way to get to that mountain. Do you know any way?"

The worker replied, "Yes there is a way. You just need to go all the way around the factory."

They thanked the worker and went that way. When they were walking that way, the owner of the factory, Mr. Bee saw them and immediately commanded the workers to capture them, and bring them to him. That is what happened. The workers were surrounding the children and they were captured. They were sent to the boss. The boss made them children workers. All the children were trapped and were put to work. There were a lot of children there and they all wanted to escape. Lisa promised all of the children that her siblings and all the children would escape.

Lisa said, "I have an idea. I overheard Mr. Bee saying that he has a magic orb. He said

that the magic orb would blink blue, if anyone answered a question correctly, and it would blink red, if the answer was wrong. He said that if anyone gives something valuable, such as a jewel or some money, then they would be able to play.”

Margo asked, “Do you think that this idea would work?”

Lisa replied back, “I think it will work, but let us at least give it a try.”

They started going to all the children and narrated everything that they just talked about. The children did not have anything valuable, such as money or jewels. Not even Lisa and her siblings have anything valuable. Suddenly, a boy named John came up and told them that he had ten dollars that he was going to use for the store behind the mountain. Lisa took the ten dollars and went directly to the boss. She made a deal with the Boss. She told him that if she could win the game, then everyone has to be freed. Both of them touched the orb. Mr. Bee started the game.

He asked, “Am I the handsomest man in all the land?”

Lisa whispered something and replied, “Yes, you are.” The Orb was Blue.

He then asked, “Am I the powerfulest man in all the lands?”

Lisa whispered something and replied, “Yes, you are.” The Orb was Blue.

Finally, Mr. Bee asked, “Am I the Richest man in all the Lands.”

Lisa whispered something and replied, “Yes, you are.” The Orb was Blue.

Lisa said, “I just have one question. Do you love your workers?”

Mr. Bee hesitated and replied, “Yeeeee?” The Orb turned Red.

Mr. Bee was lying and he lost. Just like he promised, he released the children, and he was more kind to his workers from now on.

Margo asked, “How did you do that ?”

Lisa told her that when he asked the first question, She whispered “To his Mom”, and when the second question came, She whispered “To his Workers”. Finally when the last question came, She whispered “To Himself”. They continued their journey and made it to the mountain. There was a door at the bottom of the mountain, and Lisa pushed it open. They saw lots and lots of stairs to the top.

Mint said, “Now that is a lot of stairs.”

Mint ran up all the stairs and he made it to the top. Everyone was trying their best to get up. Lisa used her super strength to stomp her way up there, and she did it. Joe saw some old vines, and climbed up. Everyone was up there. They saw an elevator come up and they saw Margo. Margo told them that there was an elevator here the whole time. They saw a door and when they went through, they were at the top of the mountain. Meanwhile, Back at the house: Grandpa forgot to tell the children something. He forgot to tell them that the gem is for good, but that it is the same gem their ancestors used to trap the nature dragon. Lisa touched the gem, which awoke the nature dragon. It started flying everywhere, and started shooting nature blasts at the kids.

Mint shouted, “What are we going to do ? We're all DOOMED!!”

Lisa had a plan and told them, “Margo, you distract the dragon. Mint, take the vine and tie up the dragon. Joe, try to see if there is a weak spot.”

Joe told Lisa, “There is a tiny blue gem, which makes the dragon out of control. Remove

the gem and it would be back to normal.”

Margo was talking with the dragon and distracting it. Mint was silently tying the vine around the dragon. Lisa was about to grab the gem. Suddenly, the eagle that grabbed the gem from the waterfall came. The dragon got up and started firing its nature blasts everywhere. Mint and Margo pulled the vines and the dragon fell. Just when everyone thought that they defeated the dragon, it woke up and freed itself. It started flying, just when Lisa was going to get the blue gem. Lisa was flying everywhere, and she fell. Mint caught her and put her down. The dragon was about to blast them, just when Lisa grabbed the Gem of Nature, and shielded everyone. The dragon blasted the blast, and when it hit the Gem, the blast reflected into the Blue Gem on the dragon’s forehead. Everyone was okay. The dragon carried all of them back to their home. The dragon became their pet. Now they live happily ever after.

THE END

Beyond the Stars

Counting Stars, by OneRepublic

By: Sanjana Vijayanand

Years later, Myles is going to college. It is a big jump for him from high school to college but he does it. He goes to Harvard University to study space.

One night, as he is coming home from his graduation for college. Mrs. Miller exclaims, “Oh Myles, I am so proud of what you’ve done son!”

“Thanks mom,” he responds.

Myles looks at his email to see something very exciting. “Mom, I just got an offer to go into space for NASA!” he screams with excitement. Happy tears rolling down his cheeks like rain.

“Honey, that is great! I do not want to ruin the moment, but my dear Myles, I really don’t have enough money to keep this house running,” she explains.

“Mom, I understand we have had some money problems, but if I take this job I can get the money for us,” he exclaims, still excited about his job offer. “The truth is back when I was in 10th grade, I didn’t use birthday money, I stole the money,” he confesses.

“MYLES, how could you, you must pay the money back to wherever you stole it from, do you understand?” she yells.

“Yes mom, I understand, now I should really go get my bags packed for this space trip!” Myles walks away.

“10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2, 1.....BLAST OFF!” the NASA staff scream.

Myles is in shock. He can’t believe it; he’s in space. As he steps on to the rocky moon, he picks up a small rock and throws it. He admires as it keeps going and going, no gravity to stop it.

He sings, “No more counting dollars, we’ll be counting stars, yeah we’ll be counting stars.” He smiles under his space suit as he gazes into the wide galaxy.

This may be very confusing for you, let me tell you the whole story!

Beep, beep, beep! Myles’s alarm shouts loudly in the morning as he pulls his blue bed covers over his face. He gets up and saunters to the bathroom. He then brushes his teeth and pulls on some black pants and his new leather jacket. Once he is downstairs, he grabs a blueberry pancake off the counter and stuffs it in his mouth.

“Come on Myles, we have to leave for school!” his mom, Mrs. Miller shouts.

“Coming mom,” he yells back. Before they leave Myles runs upstairs and sprays a lot of man perfume on. He slips on his white shoes and runs out of his tiny house like a cheetah.

Once he arrives at his high school, he walks through the crowded halls waving at people like he is a movie star. As he enters the classroom, he sits down and starts to scribble on the paper that was handed out. Myles goes to the rest of his classes continuing to not care about any of the work and assignments they do. Mrs. Miller starts to get concerned about his grades.

The next day Myles’s 10th grade teacher, Mr. Brown explains the class’s ELA assignment, “Okay class, today we are doing a big project that will be 50% of your grade. You will be researching monkeys and writing an essay on them. You will have the next two periods to complete this assignment. Remember to take your time and have fun with it!”

Right away all the other kids get to work, after a while of thinking Myles opens his computer and writes his essay. A few minutes later Myles comes up to Mr. Brown and shows him his “finished” essay.

Monkey Research Essay

By: Myles Miller

Monkey’s like to eat bananas. They also climb on trees. The end.

“Well Myles, maybe you should work on your essay a bit,” explains Mr. Brown.

“This is all I could come up with, I don’t know what else to write,” he complains.

“That’s what research is for!” responds Mr. Brown.

Later that week, as Myles was getting ready to leave the house he saw a mail letter on his small fridge. It said “payment overdue”. This makes Myles concerned, so he decides he needs to do something about it. At night, before coming home from school he goes to the convenience store to steal some money for his mom. When the store owner is busy, Myles steals the money from the cashier and stuffs it in his jacket. The store owner turns around just as Myles stuffs the money in his jacket.

“Hey kid, stores closin’ get out!” he yells.

Myles races out of the store. When he gets home he puts the money in front of his mom.

“Myles honey, what is this?” Mrs. Miller questions.

“I have extra birthday money my friends gave me mom, please use it I know you need to pay the bills,” he lies.

“Myles, thank you!” she says in a very appreciative way.

The next day, Myles wakes up to the “payment overdue” mail gone. A big grin covers his face. His mom walks down and exclaims, “Good morning, so I have seen your grades and they are not doing well. Because of that I have signed you up for an extra credit space class to get your grades up. No complaining.” she explains.

Ring! The bell has rung and now Myles is walking down to his extra credit space class.

“Why did my mom have to sign me up for this,” he thinks.

As he enters the big classroom he gazes around to see all the fascinating planets and stars. The whole classroom is filled with excited kids.

“Ah Myles, you are down here with Zach,” exclaims Mr. Moon. Myles walks down to the table right in front of the class.

“Hi, my name is Zach and my favorite star is Sirius,” explains Zach.

“Oh um, my name is Myles and I don’t really know much about stars, my mom signed me up for this class,” Myles responds. They both look towards the front as the class started. Mr. Moon explains how they were doing a space presentation with their table partners, which in Myles’s case would be Zach. Their assignment was to research the moon.

One night Myles invited Zach over to his house for a sleepover so they could work on their project. Three hours later.... They were finished with their project. They had a pillow fight, made forts, and watched movies.

The weeks zoomed by like race cars. Myles is getting a lot more interested in space and he and Zach are now best friends.

The day of their presentation.....

“Did you know the Moon's distance from Earth is about 240,000 miles (385,000 km),” Myles starts.

“The Moon has a very thin atmosphere called an exosphere,” Zach adds.

Minutes later, as Myles goes to sit down he realizes many things. He realizes that he should not be some boy who does not care about anything. He realizes that he should really put in the hard work to get what he wants. He realizes that working hard always pays off. He realizes that he finally found an interest that fascinates him, space.

Right when he gets home from his space class, he goes back to his Monkey Research Essay for Mr. Brown’s ELA class. He actually researches them and sends the new and improved essay to Mr. Brown hoping he will accept it later. The next morning as he looks at his grade it is a B+, it is a start. As the time grows Myles is getting older and older. He eventually gets the offer to work at NASA and takes it. He is more than excited to be able to research beyond the stars.

✦ **SPOTLIGHT STORIES END HERE** ✦

Caved In
Count on Me, by Bruno Mars
By: Anika Sista

“This is creepy,” Jade Castro said with a shiver. She along with her friends Ava Hudson and Elizabeth Bennett were inside a dark cave that Ava had insisted on going into. There were rumors going around that it was haunted, even more of a reason why Ava wanted to go in.

“Why did we have to come here?” Elizabeth asked.

“I just wanted to see what was inside here,” Ava reassured them, “Don’t worry, you can count on me not to get you killed.

Elizabeth sighed and they continued walking farther into the cave.

“Guys,” Jade whispered, “Look at *that*.” They turned to face the wall where Jade shone her flashlight.

A red substance was dripping along the walls and it looked like - “Blood!” Elizabeth shouted, “Oh my gosh, oh my gosh, oh my gosh! We have to get out of here!” She immediately started running towards the exit but Jade pulled her back.

“Relax. The blood’s probably fake,” Jade remarked but seeing that Elizabeth was still doubtful, she continued, “Just - imagine yourself in a happy place.”

Elizabeth sighed, “I’m in my room, on my bed writing in my diary,” she said, “Dear Diary, if you’re ever lost in the dark and you can’t see, don’t ever listen to your friends. They always have the *worst* ideas.” Jade and Ava both rolled their eyes as they continued observing the wall.

Suddenly, Jade screamed. Ava shone the flashlight towards her, making Jade’s face light up with an eerie glow.

“Guuuuuuuys,” she whispered, “I just felt a HAND grabbing my leg.” At that moment Ava’s flashlight went out, leaving them in darkness.

Elizabeth started to panic. “Jade, you’re messing with us...right? Tell me this is a joke. TELL ME!” But she barely finished her sentence before Jade screamed again and was gone. Elizabeth started to yell while Ava walked around in circles trying to find Jade with a frantic expression. She stopped.

“Elizabeth,” she stuttered, “I felt a hand on my leg too.” Elizabeth started to cry as she slid onto the floor.

“This is it,” she moaned, “The blood was a warning. We’re all gonna die.” Ava closed her eyes and took a deep, shaky breath.

“It’s okay Elizabeth,” she said, “And I know when I need it, I can count on you to help. Just...try to hold on to my hand so that the person won’t get me.” Elizabeth nodded in the dark, then held Ava’s hand as they waited in silence. A few minutes past and nothing happened. Elizabeth frowned.

“Why hasn’t anything happened yet?” she wondered aloud as she let go of Ava’s hand. That was her big mistake. “Elizabeth!” Ava yelled before disappearing. Elizabeth was frozen in

shock. Finally, she felt a hand on her leg. She closed her eyes and after a moment or so she found herself falling down into... plants? She looked all around her and saw big flowers with vines that wrapped all around her. It was like a basement under the cave - that was filled all the way with plants. She looked to her left and saw Ava and Jade struggling to take off the vines that were on them too. As soon as they saw Elizabeth, their eyebrows shot up in surprise and Jade was the first to talk.

“Elizabeth!” she said, her expression showing relief. Before Elizabeth could say anything, the plants started to move, clearing a path for a man with a top hat with a rose pinned on it, a green shirt with thorns attached to it and dark green hair that looked like the vines that covered the girls. His eyes went immediately to Elizabeth who shrank under the man’s mean glare.

“Hello Elizabeth,” he growled.

TO BE CONTINUED

Fireworks on the Fourth of July

Fireworks, by Katy Perry

By: Annika Jivrajani

On the corner of Enero street, lay a small house, number 22, to be specific, however, as little as this house was, it held a big argument.

“JUST PAY THE BILLS!” argued Joey, to his wife Samantha.

“I CAN’T PAY THE BILLS!! I DON’T HAVE A JOB!!”

“I’M NOT THE ONE WHO GOT FIRED FROM IT!”

“JOY WAS SICK!! AGAIN!!”

“YOU SHOULD HAVE LET ME HANDLE IT!!”

“YOU DON’T KNOW ANYTHING ABOUT KIDS! YOU COULDN’T EVEN BOOK A DOCTOR’S APPOINTMENT!”

With that statement, Joey had had enough, he marched out the front door, slamming it loudly. The maroon bricks on number eleven shook, the rusty door dusting off its dust. In the other room, Joy sat there on their bed, exhausted, but still crying her eyes out. Her pale hands plugged her ears closed. But still, she had heard the argument loud and clear. It was eleven in the night. Her older brother, Marcus, had been out “studying.” Joy knew Marcus wasn’t actually studying. He was at the club, drinking and smoking. It hurt Joy—but what was she to do? She was sick most of the time, normally cuddling in her bed, with Mr. Sprinkles, who was always happy with her—the last thing her grandpa gave her when—he—you know, passed.

Anyway, Joy sat there, feeling *hopeless*. Tears still sweat down her pale face like a rainstorm. Joy shuttered. She felt an icy breeze go through her.

“Well,” she thought, “*I can atleast get my blanket.*” She stood up dizzily. Her blanket was on her dresser. She leaped forward, only to have her dizziness push her to the ground. Then, everything went BLACK.

“*She fainted!*”

“*Wait! She’s awake!*”

“*Honey....it's going to be okay!*”

With ambulance sirens, that was the last thing she heard before waking up in the hospital bed in the emergency room. The hospital room was covered in butterflies that were both pink and purple. They were decorated in stripes. Joy thought the butterflies were ugly. The butterflies were so ugly that she even thought that she was going to puke. Just then she heard a familiar voice—the high pitched, songful sound. She pondered for a moment. She knew the voice, but who was it? Hmmm. A thought popped into her head. *MOM!*

She listened closely to the other voice she was talking to, who she assumed was a doctor. Her vision remained with the butterflies, because she was too exhausted to turn her head.

“Mrs. Jones. I’m sorry to inform you, but your daughter has stage four cancer. The father will be contacted.” The doctor explained. Mrs. Jones sobbed.

“My baby!” Mrs. Jones cried.

Several months passed. Then came Joy's favorite time of the year. THE FOURTH OF JULY! But Joy was undergoing treatment. She couldn't go! About a week before her dad came in to ask her a question.

“Is it okay if me and your mom and your brother can go to the fourth of July festival?” He asked.

“Sure,” Joy responded sadly.

To be continued....

College Life

Rather Be, by Clean Bandit

By: Anouk Warriar

“Wake up, Nova! Get ready! The cruise is waiting!” exclaimed Vivian, a wide grin spread across her face.

“What cruise?” screamed Nova, getting up from her bed with her hair falling over her eyes.

“Ugh. I forgot to tell you that we’re going to Tokyo for college,” she explained as she strode into her room to pack and change.

She had forgotten again! Today was the day she had to go to college.

She had thought, “We’re probably going to Harvard, but Tokyo, that was extreme traveling.” Nova got up just to see the sun. It was so bright that it made her think that it was smiling at her. She then went to brush, change, and pack her bags for Tokyo.

A few hours later... “I’m so bored! Vivi, when can we get off?!” yammered Nova, 5 minutes after they had left the dock.

“We just left the dock! Now, stop whining and get it over with, Nova!” said Vivian.

“Aw, man!” groaned Nova.

A few days later, they had reached the port of Kyoto (Tokyo), they got off the boat and on a bus to their college tour.

“Welcome, everyone! I will be your headmaster for the time you are in college! I’m Mrs. Nakamura. Welcome to Genshin Academy, Tokyo!” boomed Mrs. Nakamura over the loudspeaker.

The next day...

“Good morning, teacher!” said the class as the teacher walked into the room.
“Good morning, class! Konnichiwa! I’m Ms. Suzuki, and I will be your teacher for the year until you graduate! So, let’s get cracking! The first subject: Art! Who painted the Mona Lisa?” she asked.

”Leo Da Vinci?” asked Nova. “Nova, you are partly correct, but it’s Leonardo Da Vinci,” said Ms. Suzuki. Nova had made an enemy. Her name was Kai-Yun. Kai-Yun snickered.

“Poor Nova’s so babyish that she doesn’t even know how to say, Leonardo Da Vinci!” Then, Kai-Yun and her friends Jin and Jiang-kook started to laugh.

“Ugh. Vivian, when can we strike back at them? I’m bored!” whispered Nova.

“Nova, they’re just trying to make you mad. Ignore them for a few days and they will stop.” The two then stopped chatting and focused on their lesson.

New-city Girl Problems, Book One: First Week Stinks!

Party in the USA, by Miley Cyrus

By: Avnika Nandini Prakash

(Warning!! This book will have a cliffhanger!)

Saturday, March 5th 2022:

One day, Addison Riecke got off her moving truck. She arrived in Las Vegas! Addison was worried she wouldn't fit in, but her mom told her to think positive. She missed her friends

back at her old town already. Well, at least she got their phone number. She was going to be in a cabin for girls and boys to meet new friends to get used to the state, instead of staying alone at her new house for a week. She got to her cabin. “(*sigh*).....You can do this, Addison. You can do this,” she Addison.

“Hello!” she said cheerfully, opening the cabin door. Everyone stopped whatever they were doing, and stared at Addison.

“Heh, heh,” Addison nervously laughed, “What am I thinking?!” Addison said in her mind to herself. Addison knew it was going to be a loooong week.

Wednesday, March 9th 2022 for some reason:

“Yawn!” Addison woke up in her cabin. “My tummy’s turnin’ and I’m feeling kinda homesick. Too much pressure, and I’m nervous,” Addison silently sang to herself, “And I don’t think I’ll make friends, but at least I have Ivy,” she reminded herself.

Before she fell asleep last night, she AT LEAST made one friend. I mean like, literally! How is it possible to have only ONE friend?! Oh, right back to the story. Her friend’s name was Ivy Green. Ivy told Addison about a girl she met in preschool. Her name was Distey. Then Addison told Ivy that SHE had a friend in preschool, and her name was Ivabela. BOTH of their friends moved away. Addison said that Ivabela moved to Las Vegas. Ivy said that Distey moved to New York city. Addison said that SHE also used to live in New York city.

“Weird!!” they both yelled at the exact same time. Then they started laughing. She also made two enemies. Their names were MacKenzie Hollister and the second enemy’s name was Tiffany Golden. Ivy was already enemies with them. Have I mentioned that Addison had one older sister, one older brother, and one younger sister? Well, she did! Her older sister’s name was Misty, her older brother’s name was Adrien, and her younger sister’s name was Maya. And boy, was life tough with them!

Back to the story...

“Hey Ivy! Wake up! It’s time for breakfast!” said Addison looking under her bunk bed. Addison slept at the top since she was new. Ivy slept at the bottom.

“Okay, Okay, I’m coming!” replied Ivy. For breakfast they had pancakes. MacKenzie eyed Addison all evil-like. When Ivy and Addison realized MacKenzie was staring at them, they just rolled their eyes at her.

Then Tiffany came out of nowhere and went up to Addison and shrieked, “OMG Addise!! Your sister’s blog is super chic! BTW, You got a bug in your hair!! Ick!!!” Addison immediately dropped her fork.

“Where?! Where?!” Addison asked. MacKenzie smirked.

Ivy realized that MacKenzie and Tiffany were just messing with Addison. She was just about to tell Addison that they were tricking her, when Tiffany innocently said, "Let me get it off you!"

Now MacKenzie was giggling. Then a few more CCPs (cute, cool, popular) joined MacKenzie. Tiffany started messing up Addison's long brown silky hair. Fun fact: Addison doesn't have bangs. Ivy covered her eyes because she didn't want to see her best friend's hair getting messed up by her enemy. Now the whole cafeteria was laughing. "So.....Did you get the bug out?? Addison asked, blowing her hair out of her face .

"Oh..there wasn't a bug in your hair bye!" Tiffany quickly said and she zoomed next to MacKenzie. Big fat tears rolled down Addison's cheeks as she fixed her hair and threw her breakfast tray in the trash and sat on her cabin couch.

"I'm so stupid. I'll never fit in." Addison said in her mind to herself. Ivy quickly finished up her breakfast and sat next to Addison.

"You okay?" Ivy asked.

"Yeah..." sniffed Addison wiping a tear, "I just want to go home. Checking out my new house. But thanks to my mom, I'm stuck in this boot camp for a week. And now, those CCP queens (MacKenzie and Tiffany), they are just ruining my life more than my annoying siblings!! At least I have you." Addison said, fisting up her hand.

"Actually... Tomorrow...(*sigh*)..I'm going home. Here's my number and Address. I'm just gonna pack..." said Ivy, getting up from the couch and giving her a piece of paper that contained Ivy's phone number and address . Addison started to tear up. She bit her lips so she wouldn't start crying. It was just Wednesday! They had to be apart for TWO days! Tomorrow, Addison was on her own.

"Oh.... I'll be in bed.." Addison wilted. When she got in bed, she had a good cry.

Let's go on to Ivy...

"Sleeping bag. Tops. Bottoms. Hair accessories. Picture with me and Addise. Wait.....wha?" Ivy leaned close to the picture, "I don't remember taking this pic with Addise. We both look really young. And what's with the back - Oh. Oh my. Oh my god," said Ivy, looking at the background.

"Are they both?....No it can't be.....Addison and Distey are the same people?!" Then Tiffany and MacKenzie pounded on the door.

Since Ivy didn't know who was knocking, she said, "Who is it?"

Then Tiffany swung the door open. Though MacKenzie and Tiffany were dressed very oddly. They looked like counselors, in shirts with the logo: LV STATE CAMP printed on the shirts. "LV" stands for Las Vegas.

"I'm looking for Ivy Green. Oh! you must be her! You're coming with me." Tiffany said, in a very low and..um..weird accent.

MacKenzie snickered. "Quiet down, would ya?!" Tiffany whispered to MacKenzie silently. Ivy didn't hear.

"Um.....okay.. Let me just finish packing." When Ivy finished packing, she went with the "counselors". Luckily, they just brought her safely home.

Back to Addison...

Normally, when Addison was upset about something, she would look into drawers to keep her distracted. So that's what she did. She found a copy of the same picture Ivy saw.

"What's with this pic? I don't remember taking this pic with Ivy. And what's with the backgrou-....." Addison paused. Then she covered her mouth, "O..M..G....Ivy is Ivabela?! I think I thought that Distey was REAL name so I think I kinda told her.....Okay Addison, just go in there and tell her that you're Distey and you're sorry for making this a big deal. Do this, for your family. Do this, for Ivy. Do this, to stop talking to myself," Addison opened the door nervously.

"Hey Ivy. I'm sorry I made it such a big deal that you were leaving so I want to tell you that," Addison babbled, "That I'm actually Dist-.....Ivy? Where are you? This place looks so dull." Addison searched around. She found a note. It was from Ivy!! Addison was relieved that Ivy at least left a note!!

It said: *Dear Addison,*

*It turns out that I'm going back home TODAY. I have no idea why I am,
But these counselors told me to come with them, because I'm leaving today.
Yay me!! But I still know that you're upset. I got the information yesterday
That I'm going home. I felt REALLY guilty, so I didn't want to tell you. But
Now I feel so pathetic!! I wish I told you yesterday during dinner. Or during
Breakfast today! U won't believe this, but I figured out that YOU'RE Distey!
Now I know why "Ivy" sounds the same as "Iva" in my nickname! Tho I don't
Know why my nickname was "Ivabela" instead of "Isabela"! Anyway, now that
I know you would NEVER betray me, I'm really sorry. Oh! The counselors are
Calling me! I'll miss u!!*

Gotta go!

Ivy Green



Addison just stared at the note. Soon it was lunchtime. They had pizza and Donuts for lunch. She was eating like a robot the whole lunch. Pretty much the rest of the DAY she acted like a robot. But only during bedtime she had millions of questions spinning in her head like: What was tomorrow going to be like without Ivy? What was Ivy doing at home? But the main

question in Addison's head was: What was the reason Ivy had to leave a day early? And Why? Addison thought and thought until she got sleepy and pretty soon, she was sound asleep.

Thursday:

Addison had just woken up, all bright and cheerful. But then she remembered about Ivy, “(*sigh*)....What will I do without you, Ivy?” Addison pretended that she was talking to Ivy. Soon it was breakfast. Addison had toast, choco milk, and a chocolate-chip cookie. She sat alone. Then all of a sudden, The new girl sat down at her table.

“Hi! My name is Serena! I'm new!” Said the new girl.

“Um.... I can see that.” said Addison, looking at her turkey-cheese sandwich. She hadn't seen anything like it for BREAKFAST.

“Yeah... My name's Addison. You could just call me Addise. My family calls me Addisie. Only my older siblings call me Addise,” said Addison.

“I know you! You lost your friend! Maybe I could... fill in for her?” Serena said, scooting closer to Addison. Then it became clear to Addison that Serena didn't like Ivy, but loved Addison.

Then Addison shot at Serena, “I don't mean to be rude, Miss Selfish, you'll never fill in for Ivy!” Serena looked shocked. Pretty much the whole CAFETERIA was looking at them. Man, Addison was mad. Serena only liked Addison because of her sister's blog. So she gave Misty a call.

“Misty! I want you to take a break from your BLOG!!” Addison shrieked.

“Sheesh... did you seriously call me without a hi? You're crazy. So... what do you want? Oh... My Blog? Never!! I don't know why I would do that! I won't get many views! I'm recording now, you know, sis! Hey, foggy mists! It's ya girl Misty!” Misty happily said, striking poses. Misty called her blog “MISTY's AWESOME LIFE!!” Addison had no time for this! All she needed was for Misty to take a loooong break for her blog. She didn't know it would be this hard! Now to her, it looked like she was going to have a long life in Las Vegas. And worst of all, she was just at the beginning!

End of book one...

You may know the cabin girls well, but there is more to tell...
Stuff about:

Mr. and Mrs. Green, Ivy's parents

Mr. and Mrs. Riecke, Addison's parents

Addison Riecke's Siberian kitten, Pepper, Persian kitten, Puffsie, and Ragdoll kitten, Mallowie.

Next book: Girlfriend, wait up! Coming soon in April, 2022!!

Have High Hopes
High Hopes, by Panic! At The Disco
By: Jasveet Kaur

Fast Forward →

“Didn’t have a dime, but I always had a vision,” Joy said to the news reporters that were bombarding her.

“But then how did you become so famous and so wealthy so fast that we’re literally sitting on a couch made of gold,” inquired the reporters.

In reply, Joy said, “Let me tell you the story.”

Back at the beginning...

“Mom, I’m going to the farm,” I shouted.

“Joy, just wait,” replied my mom, “Just come here. I think we should make you go to college.”

“But how will we pay?” I asked.

“Your cousin Amy is a lawyer and she always has extra money. If we ask her for college fees, she might lend us some. After you become a Family medicine physician, you’ll get paid 500 grand a year! You’ll definitely have enough to pay back the money your dear cousin Amy gave you and I know you can do it because you are the smartest kid I know. Got to have high hopes for a living!”

On the way to the Farm...

“Hi Joy,” smirked Natalie, A.K.A the Big Boss. She bullied me because she was a doctor and I was a farmer.

“Just be quiet, Natalie.”

“But I just said hi. Oh! Did that bother you? Are you a cry-baby?”

“Well, but I just said be quiet. Oh! Are you bothered? Do *you* wanna tell mommy?”

“Hmph,” moaned Natalie, as she walked away.

“I guess that did it,” Joy said to herself.

When I reached the farm, I did work, but only for 3 hours. Then I decided to go home.

Back at home (again)

“Mom, I’m gonna go to college,” I said.

“Wonderful! I already called your cousin and she gave us money!”

“Then, I’ll go right now!”

At Harvard (the University)

“Hi, um, I would like to apply for this college,” I said to the headmaster, “Can I join now?”

“Of course! I already want you! You talk properly and know what math is so come on in!”

“Everyone, this is Joy! She will be joining us!”

After 4 years of college

“And that is how I became a Family medicine physician!”

THE END...

The Three Musketeers

Bellyache, by Billie Eilish

By: Mahiya Srivatava

“But now I got a bellyache,” read Vinnie. Hello, my name is Vinnie and I am an officer. You may be wondering what I am reading and who I am but, for that I will have to start at the beginning of this case. For starters, you will have to know about Cooper, Lilly, and Phoenix - Satan's Three Musketeers or as we call them Satan's little devils. This group of teenagers are known to cause mischief around our parks in Arizona. Be careful you wouldn't want to fall into one of their schemes.

Anyhow, let me begin with this case from the start. It was a bright sunny day and the sun was blazing on our crops. The Three Musketeers thought it would be a good idea to plot a scheme. They started by going to the bank and taking out a loan now this would be alright but everyone knows that the Three Musketeers are always up to no good.

Anyways, the bank let them take a loan for \$200,000. You might be wondering what they would do with so much money, well they were planning on running away. You see months before this Cooper's mother had passed away and it has been extremely hard on him. Now, the Three Musketeers are rebels and they just wanted to run away from their troubles. Well, on this day, they started heading for the road with their belongings. They stopped by an ice-cream truck that was abandoned. They immediately went inside to see if anything was there, but all that was left was a bag full of rubies. They immediately took the bag and started driving the truck. As they were almost about to exit their town, the Three Musketeers accidentally left one of Phoenix's baseball cap back at the field where they had found the truck. The Three Musketeers had passed their town now and didn't know where they were driving to.

Just then, Cooper feels guilty of taking the rubies and starts writing his thoughts in a journal.

“I'm bitin' my nails. I'm too young to go to jail. It's kinda funny.” Lilly stops the truck at a gas station and gets some snacks as she gets some snacks Phoenix steals a pack of gam, beef jerky, and a gift card for \$100.

“Did you get the card?” Lilly asks.

“Yeah, hurry up before they notice,” Phoenix replies. As they hit the road Cooper continues to write his thoughts.

“They'll be here pretty soon lookin' through my room.” He talks about how the police are going to realize soon how much they had stolen and all the crime they had done. Just then, Lilly starts speeding up the van and is going really fast when she hits an old lady. They immediately go outside and check on her and see that they accidentally killed her. Instead of getting the lady help they drive away as if nothing happened. But just as they drove away a young girl had seen what had happened.

The Three Musketeers, who were once teenagers, are now 3 adults who are very famous. No one had found out about they're previous life because they had bribed the government to delete their old records. On one fine evening, as the Three Musketeers are working a young woman who is a lawyer walks in. She looks very stern and has come to discuss a complaint she has with the Three Musketeers. Now the Three Musketeers have many people who hate them but something was different about this lady. She was a lawyer who was there with a case. As soon as Lilly saw the file, she almost turned redder than a tomato.

“Phoenix, Cooper, that's the file we couldn't find and burn,” Lilly whispered.

“OH NO,” Phoenix and Cooper responded.

The lady started to talk to the Three Musketeers and explained how she saw what they had done that sunny day and that the old lady they had killed was her widowed mother. The lady had gathered all the evidence she needed to put the Three Musketeers in prison. She started to walk out the doors as the three looked at each other with guilt and shame. They were able to run away from their actions a long time ago but have to own up to them now. That's where this story ends and where I come in. The lady (aka Gracie) is actually my best friend and when she came to me for this case she brought a very interesting journal from Cooper and the title of it was called “Bellyache.”
